

Independence, Power, and Therapeutic Binds



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AGENDA

Supporting Healthy Independence &
Power

Unbinding Autonomy from Threat

Understanding Therapeutic Binds

Q & A

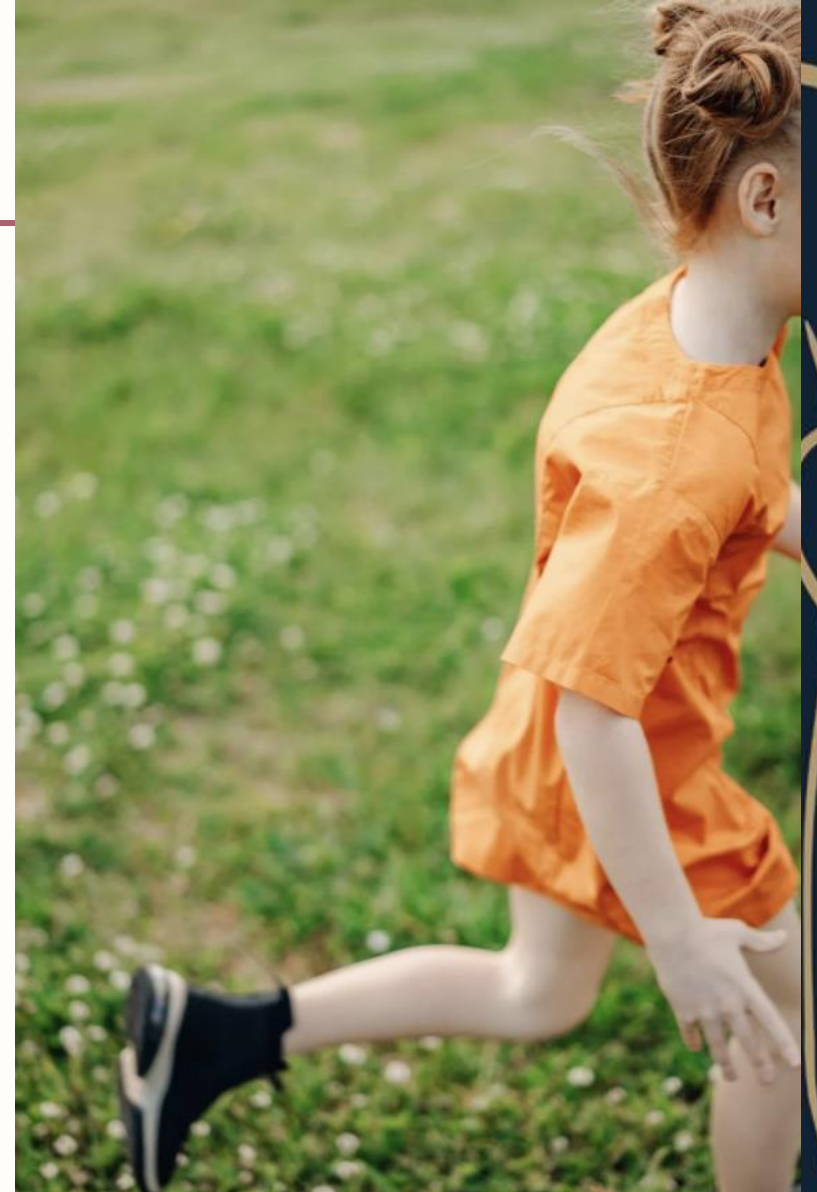
Breakout Sessions

Arriving Practice

- Setting with Choice – slowing attention, orient
- Body Edges (centering practice)
- Moving “Joy” – taking space with intention

Core Developmental Task

- Emergence of autonomy and will
- Child experiments with choice, power and resistance
- "I am separate, I have preference, my actions matter."
- "I can be me and stay connected."



Healthy Independence

- Child's initiatives are supported
- Adults allow safe autonomy
- Mistakes are tolerated without shame



Independence

- Child's strong desire to choose (clothes, food etc.)
- Repeated use of "No" (verbal and non-verbal, body resistance)
- Insistence on doing tasks alone
- Emotional intensity when actions are blocked

If these needs are unsupported, child complies without selfhood or resistance in power struggle.



Power

Power emerges when child learns their actions affect others

I matter, I affect the world

This stage is not about separation,
it's about **differentiation within relationship**.

Power emerges through:

- Choice
- Preference
- “No”
- Exploration with a safe return



Relational Binds

- Trauma at this stage creates binds between autonomy and connection.
- “ Be independent, but only the way I approve.”
- “ You’re good when you don’t need anything.”
- ”Strong feelings lead to rejection or punishment.”

Client feel...

- Confusion about self-expression
- Anxiety about choices
- Power struggles or emotional shut down

Therapeutic Binds

These are the double binds that freeze power:

- If I assert → I lose connection
- If I comply → I lose myself
- If I explore → I'm unsafe
- If I depend → I'm weak
- If I say no → I'm bad
- Therapeutic interventions are about unbinding autonomy from threat.

Unbinding Autonomy from Threat

Providing a Missing Experience

- Client needs to have a direct experience that is relational, often involves accessing the younger child part that holds that time frame and beliefs
- Missing experiences both allow for what has not been and provides in in real time
- The anticipated relational response softens, the deeper layers of yearning can be experienced



Therapeutic Attitude

- Explore “wanting and choice”
- Allow client to discover preferences without judgment or shame, guilt
- Naming the binds and explore the somatic impact (dispel the grip by naming them)
- Autonomy is micro-movement
 - Power is not dramatic, it starts with orienting, leaning, pausing, choosing.
- “No” precedes “Yes”
 - Authentic connection depends on a lived, embodied “no.”
- Regulation follows permission
 - The nervous system settles when agency is restored.
- Relationship must survive difference
- The client learns power only if the therapist *stays* when the client diverges

Key Therapeutic Practices

- Name feelings without judgment
- Offer real choices “ You can decide if you want to explore this right now or not”
- Hold boundaries with warmth
- Stay relational when client is frustrated, angry or challenges the power dynamics
- Explore a safe “no”
- Play and exploration without expectation
- Staying in the “dilemma” and finding new options

Exc. Unbinding Autonomy from Threat

Purpose” Restore agency without rupture

1. Therapist:

- Track micro-movements of agency
- Offer permission before regulation
- Stay connected when the client diverges
- Avoid persuasion, encouragement, or interpretation

2. Observer tracks:

- Where and how power appears in the body and expressions
- Where and how it collapses
- Whether connection survives difference

Cont. Exc. Unbinding Autonomy from Threat

Therapist Tasks

1. Client Prompt:
 - “Let your body show me a ‘no’—without words.”
2. Track the body: Jaw, Shoulders, Hands, Feet, Back body support
3. Slow the pace & Track micro-movements
4. Name what you notice: “I saw your hand pause—that matters.”, “Your shoulders pulled back slightly.”
5. Key Relational Message (say once, simply)
 - “Your ‘no’ doesn’t push me away—it helps me stay with you.”
6. Explore the how the impulse of autonomy IN relationship emerges.



Therapeutic Binds

Therapeutic Bind:

Autonomy vs. Loss of Connection Bind

“If I assert myself , I will be abandoned.”

- Collapses after self assertion and apologizes
- Hesitation to state needs
- Hypervigilance of the therapist's actions
- Track for dropped shoulders, shallow breath, reduced body tone, vigilant gaze

Somatic Interventions

- **Pendulation between choice and connection:**
Invite the client to say a preference, then orient to the therapist's steady presence.
- **Chest & spine support:**
Encourage gentle spinal lengthening while naming wants.
- **Breath with contact:**
Slow exhale while therapist verbally affirms staying connected.
 - *"Notice your body as you say that—and notice I'm still right here."*

Therapeutic Bind:

Power-Danger Bind

“My intensity or will is overwhelming or unsafe to others.”

- Strong emotions were labeled “too much”
- Power was met with fear, punishment, or shaming
- The child internalized fear of their own vitality
 - Intellectualizing anger
 - Humor as deflection
 - Chronic muscular tension (jaw, hands, thighs)
 - Freeze or hyper-control around intensity

Somatic Interventions

- **Isometric containment:**
Pressing hands into thighs or wall to feel strength without discharge.
- **Growling or voiced exhales (very contained):**
Let sound move energy safely.
- **Titrated boundary movements:**
 - Small pushing motions while tracking regulation.
 - *“Let’s feel 5% of that strength—just enough to notice, not overwhelm.”*
- **Go slowly- avoid pushing:**
 - *Bitesize the experiences*

Therapeutic Bind:

The Choice vs. Punishment Bind

“I’m asked to choose, but I’m wrong no matter what I pick.”

- Choices were offered without true consent, or reversed, corrected, or criticized
- The child learned that choice leads to shame
 - Freeze responses when asked preferences
 - Chronic self-doubt
 - Outsourcing authority
 - Somatic signs: held breath, stillness, numbness

Somatic Interventions

- **Binary choice with body tracking:**
“Notice your body as you imagine option A... now option B.”
- **Orienting to impulse:**
Help client feel *micro-movements* toward preference.
- **Choice without consequence:**
Low-stakes decisions paired with safety cues.
“*There’s no right answer here—and we can change it at any time.*” (needs to be modeled by therapist)

Other Somatic Interventions

- Spine (upright autonomy)
- Hands (agency and boundary)
- Jaw (suppressed “no”)
- Breath and Body Movements (permission to take up space)
- Playful arguments (Yes-No, staying in relationship)

Core Missing Experiences

- It is okay to want what you want.
- Your power and independence do not threaten connection or love.
- You remain seen, valued, and connected when you choose yourself.



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QUESTIONS



BREAKOUT SESSIONS

Discussion Prompts

1. How did your family system respond to your early expressions of independence?
2. Which emotions were welcomed, discouraged, or punished during your early autonomy development (1.5–3 years)?
3. How do autonomy and power show up in your therapeutic relationships, and how have you worked with these dynamics?